
Bernard Lonergan as Pastoral Theologian

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The title of this article will surprise those who have thought Bernard Lonergan to be primarily a speculative theologian isolating himself from the involvement that is so characteristic of contemporary theology. But it is largely with the purpose of correcting such a view that I have chosen this topic, and it seems appropriate that the correction should appear in the organ of that Gregorian University where Lonergan wrote most of the abstruse Latin theology which earned him the reputation of being excessively intellectual in his interests.

Still, I do not regard the mere reversal of mistaken views on this point as a very onerous task: it will be a simple matter to adduce evidence that from start to finish of his career Lonergan was oriented and guided by a deep-lying pastoral concern. The real problem is to relate his speculative work to that guiding motivation. We can invoke, for a general answer, one of his favorite phrases from Toynbee: it was a withdrawal intended for a return. But what went on during the withdrawal, what was Lonergan up to, how did he envisage his return, and — the question most immediately pressing on us, his heirs, since Lonergan never himself effected that return on the scale his own idea demands — how does one go about the task of completing his work and adding the direct involvement he always intended?

These are the questions that most concern me in this article. But all things in order. Let me first briefly document the case for the fact of his pastoral intent, then go on to ask what he was up to in the long years of his wrestling with the nature and functions of theology, to conclude, in a third part, with some reflections on the task he has left for his theological heirs to accomplish.

I. *The Fact: Two Pieces of Evidence*

A pastoral concern marked Lonergan's career from beginning to end: that is so clear to those who know his history that I do not

propose to delay on the matter. Two soundings will be enough to demonstrate it.

One of these regards his interest in economics and takes us first into a period of his life that may be relatively unknown to most readers of *GREGORIANUM*: the early years from the summer of 1940 to the December of 1946, when he was teaching at the College of the Immaculate Conception in Montreal and regularly writing short articles and reviews for the English-language diocesan weekly in that city. (One could list articles of piety too, written during this and the subsequent Toronto period, but I confine the evidence to items of a more academic nature.) Now it is quite remarkable that, some thirty years before the famous conference at Medellin, the concerns of the young Lonergan bore close resemblance to those that would surface in other lands and other contexts among the liberation theologians. Lonergan's context at the time was Canadian, and so we find him writing on such topics as Quebec's opportunity (some years before the quiet revolution there!), on the Antigonish movement to help depressed fishermen, on the needed rebirth of rural living, and so on.

There is no need to document in detail this little batch of writings, but they do take on considerable importance in view of developments at the end of Lonergan's career, so a few brief quotations on matters economic and political will be illuminating for our overall purpose. Thus, the question is put, "Why is the control of industry in the hands of fewer and fewer?" (May 2, 1941). We are told: "Unless the masses achieve economic independence, then ... [democracy] will be a noble experiment that failed" (*ibid.*). There is reference to the way "governmental functions... have been multiplying and accumulating for a century under the evil influence of a mistaken economic system" so that there is little use working out "an elaborate palliative for a monstrous disease" (April 10, 1943).¹

The quotations themselves are but straws in a wind, the direction and force of which were then unknown and appeared in full clarity only thirty years later, when we learn that back in the 1940s Lonergan was at work on a thorough analysis of the economic

¹ When Lonergan first wrote for this diocesan newspaper (in 1941), it was called *The Montreal Beacon*; then it became *The Canadian Register: Quebec Edition* (1942 ff.). Researchers will be able, from the dates I have given, to find the relevant article or review in the photocopies of the Lonergan Research Institute in Toronto, or in one of the various Lonergan Centers, including that of the North American College, Rome. The newspaper itself is practically inaccessible to most of my readers.

situation. The situation itself was pastoral *par excellence*: we had just lived through a decade of economic depression and abject suffering for millions, and the crying need of the times came piteously to Lonergan's ears. His concern, however, found expression, not in establishing soup-kitchens — a task he would of course recognize as essential — but in striving to achieve a fundamental understanding of the economic reality. Various bizarre theories on relief of the crisis had surfaced, in Canada as elsewhere, in the 1930s; Catholic moral theology had laid down the precept that employers must pay a living wage, often with the only result that Catholic employers who obeyed the precept went bankrupt, leaving the field to their less scrupulous rivals; and Lonergan realized that the real solution could come only from a better economics. In other words, a viable moral theology in this area required a theory of economics as much as a viable systematic theology required a philosophy. It was under such influences that he began to think out in the thirties and commit to paper in the forties his own very personal theory.

The work on economics that Lonergan composed in 1944 and later entitled *An Essay in Circulation Analysis* remained a typescript stowed away in a filing cabinet for over thirty years. But the ideas kept appearing elsewhere, notably in Chapter 7 of *Insight*.² This chapter, a study of human affairs that could well be named a liberation philosophy, deals among other topics with the emergence, rise, and functioning of technology, capital formation, economic and political systems, and the variety of cultures; with the options of liberalism, capitalism, and totalitarianism; with the demand for a creative human role in the making of history; and so on. The same themes crop up continually in the Latin theology of the next decade and, leaping over the intervening years, we find them again in Chapter 2 of *Method in Theology*, where they are summarized and carried forward.³

It was, however, long afterward, when Lonergan returned late in life to his economics typescript, that the full evidence of the work's pastoral orientation appeared. His courses at Boston College during these declining years remain unpublished, but are well recorded, so

² *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, London: Longmans, Green and Co., 1957; the 4th edition is available in paperback from Harper & Row, San Francisco, and Darton, Longman & Todd, London. There is evidence that Chapters 6 and 7 of the book were the first to be written; this would date them around 1949.

³ *Method in Theology*, London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1972.

we can document his continuing interest in those questions which engage the liberation theologians (to whom indeed he now refers as one of his sources). For the seventies, far from having found a solution to the problems of the thirties, had instead simply added a host of others. So Lonergan is led to discuss the factors involved in recession, depression, and crash in the economy; but he deals also with the colonial economy, armaments, unemployment, unions, inflation; he goes beyond national boundaries to talk of spheres of influence, protectorates, and undeveloped or underdeveloped countries. There is censure of "profits...reaped by owners who reside elsewhere," of "a vicious circle of ever more demands for a larger money supply with no increase in real income," and of situations in which "there has emerged in fact if not in name the welfare state." And there is a lengthy section on that chief target of liberation theology, the multinational corporation. These and other topics are discussed in the context of his personal contribution to economics, and the whole work belongs in the still wider context of his dialectic of history, one that would move beyond the Marxist dialectic to a reformation, or counter-reformation, that is even more necessary in economics today than it was in the religious sphere five centuries ago.⁴

It is extraordinarily fascinating, this lifelong concern with the realities of economics, and it demonstrates perfectly the mode of Lonergan's pastoral involvement: concern for the poor and oppressed, but action at the very roots of the problem.⁵ We shall

⁴ *An Essay in Circulation Analysis*, unpublished typescript used in a course at Boston College, 1979-1980. Note that the work exists in several forms; my quotations are from the one dated in the spring of 1980, pp. 67-73; the reference to liberation theology is on p. 75, the section on multinational corporations on pp. 75-103. — For a somewhat expanded discussion of these questions see my article, "Bernard Lonergan and Liberation Theology," in WALTER L. YSAAC (ed.), *The Third World and Bernard Lonergan: A Tribute to a Concerned Thinker*, Manila: Cardinal Bea Institute Press, 1986.

⁵ Lonergan's direct exploration of economics may obscure the fact that his thought has profound implications in fields he did not explore. Let me take as an example the life of the unborn, and put together three separate passages from his writings. In *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, University of Notre Dame Press, 1967, we find his position on the soul as *logos*: "the denial of soul today is really the denial of the intelligible, the denial that understanding, knowing a cause, is knowing anything real" (pp. 20-21). The original of this study appeared in *Theological Studies* in 1946; it was followed by the study, in *Insight*, of finality as the immanent intelligibility of development (Ch. 15, see especially "Potency and Finality," pp. 444-451, and "Human Development," pp. 469-479), which allows us to add a dynamic aspect to the otherwise static notion of *logos*. Thirdly, there is his study of

return to that mode of involvement in due course, but we have yet to present our second piece of evidence on the fact. It lies in the field of theology and theological method, which was central for Lonergan throughout his academic career: even in economics his controlling motivation was theological. So we turn to the already mentioned work he called *Method in Theology*.

This book, as is well known, deals in the programmatic part called the Foreground with eight functional specialties, knit together in a close relationship that yet allows each to contribute to theology according to its own identity and its own specific purpose. Now the present point has to do with the eighth specialty, Communications, which in Lonergan's thinking is coincident with pastoral theology and is the crowning exercise of the whole unitary process. First, then, it is coincident with pastoral theology: when Lonergan would show the kinship of his specialties with divisions and procedures already operative in theology, he will say, "Thus, our divisions of the second phase — foundations, doctrines, systematics, and communications — correspond roughly to the already familiar distinctions between fundamental, dogmatic, speculative, and pastoral or practical theology."⁶ And when he comes to communications itself and would illustrate it concretely, he will say, "if the reader wishes to contemplate theologians at work in our eighth functional specialty, I would refer him to the five-volume *Handbuch der Pastoraltheologie* edited by F.X. Arnold, F. Klostermann, K. Rahner, V. Schurr, and L. Weber."⁷ Next, communications crowns the whole process of theology: "It is a major concern, for it is in this final stage that theological reflection bears fruit. Without the first seven stages, of course, there is no fruit to be borne. But without the last the first seven are in vain, for they fail to mature."⁸ We may add that, in one of his last papers, when he was reflecting on the Second Vatican Council and on Chenu's analysis of its pastoral nature, Lonergan remarked: "Now I feel that Fr. Chenu's position is unanswerable,

the self-mediation of an organism, worked out in lectures at Gonzaga University, Spokane, and Thomas More Institute, Montreal, in 1963: "The organism lives, it has a reality that is superior to the whole business of cells and their differentiation and specialization"; it is a *self-mediation*. See LONERGAN's "The Mediation of Christ in Prayer," *METHOD: Journal of Lonergan Studies*, Vol. 2, No. 1, March 1984, pp. 1-20 (quotation, p. 7). The three ideas linked in series would be highly illuminating, it seems to me, for studies in embryology.

⁶ *Method*, p. 136.

⁷ *Ibid.*, pp. 355-356.

⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 355.

and in fact I include the pastoral function as the crowning specialty in my *Method of Theology*.”⁹

The basic fact of Lonergan’s pastoral orientation is, I think, established, but it will leave many readers with a puzzle: why was he not more directly involved in the questions of the day that so exercised other theologians? what was he up to in that massive withdrawal that characterized the central period of his life, a withdrawal so prolonged that he lacked time at the end for the return for which it was intended? That is the real question. Absence of a clear answer accounts for much mistaken understanding of his purpose, and so I will deal with it at somewhat greater length in my next section. I confine my remarks, however, to the area of central importance: his work on theology and on theological method.

II. *Lonergan’s Strategy*

What, then, was Lonergan doing in his years of withdrawal from the life of the marketplace and even from the pulpits of our churches? In a generic way the answer lies in the strategy of his planning and the mode of his involvement: he would get to the bottom of things. To grant that there was a strategy in his planning need not conceal from us that he was under a kind of compulsion as well: he *had* to get to the bottom of things. Like a famous reformer, there he took his stand because he could do no other. We have seen this in his economics, where he felt compelled to get behind the precept of a living wage to the most fundamental analysis; we shall see it now in his area of special interest, the Christian message and the role of theology in teaching and preaching that message. Here the question is complicated by extensive developments in Lonergan’s thinking as he wrestled with the problem, but study of that development is *de rigueur* if we are to grasp with any accuracy what he was up to. We can simplify the study, as I will now, but we cannot by-pass it. Hence the following division.

1. *The Early Period*

There are various ways, all somewhat arbitrary, of dividing Lonergan’s career. For present purposes I find it useful to speak of

⁹ “Horizons and Transpositions,” Boston College Lonergan Workshop, 1979; I quote from Lonergan’s unpublished typescript (p. 17), reproducing his mistake in the title of his own book!

three periods, beginning with his thirteen years (1940-1953) in the Jesuit theologates of Montreal and Toronto. It happens that, soon after, he published in *GREGORIANUM* an article that not only marks the culmination of this first period, but also begins the transition to the next. Historically, then, it is of special significance; moreover, its content provides a shortcut to the thinking of the early Lonergan on theology.

The title of the article is already luminous, for it was called "Theology and Understanding," and from start to finish of his career understanding was a focus for Lonergan.¹⁰ In this early period, indeed, it received more than the lion's share of attention: understanding was the very business of the theologian. Even now, however, understanding was not a private reward and privilege for the exclusive enjoyment of the theologian, but was to enter into the theologian's preaching of the word of God. Here is a relevant passage in which Lonergan, speaking of the *ordo doctrinae* of Thomas Aquinas (which is almost equated here with theological understanding), writes as follows:

With some approximation to a single view it gives rise to an apprehension of the exact content and the exact implications of the many mysteries in their many aspects. That single view both simplifies and enriches one's own spiritual life and it bestows upon one's teaching the enviable combination of sureness of doctrine with versatility of expression. Finally, the single view remains, for it is fixed upon one's intellectual memory. So we find that non-Catholic clergymen, often more learned in scripture and the fathers, preach from their pulpits the ideas put forward in the latest stimulating book or article, while the Catholic priest, often burdened with sacerdotal duties and administrative tasks, spontaneously expounds the epistle or gospel of the Sunday in the light of an understanding that is common to the ages.¹¹

¹⁰ His students will remember his frequent reference to two favorite passages. One is the *Quodlibetum* in which Thomas Aquinas notes the difference between merely giving authorities for doctrine, thus sending pupils away with empty minds, and bringing to light the ground of the doctrine and sending them away with some understanding; see *Method*, p. 357. The other is the "aliquam intelligentiam, eamque fructuosissimam" of Vatican I; see again *Method*, pp. 309, 321, 323, 336.

¹¹ "Theology and Understanding," *GREGORIANUM* 35 (1954) 630-648 (quotation, pp. 640-641); republished, *Collection: Papers by Bernard Lonergan, S.J.*, New York: Herder and Herder, 1967, pp. 121-141 (quotation, p. 133) — the book is now out of print.

I very much doubt that Lonergan would have wished, twenty years later, to defend all the views of this article or even of the quoted paragraph, but dated though those views may be they still witness to the ultimate pastoral purpose of his theology.

At this time, however, a development of considerable significance is beginning, as appears from this very article. For, though he still claims validity for Thomist thought in speculative theology, Lonergan is beginning to realize that the reign of that theology is over; it must step down to the level of partnership with other functions. There is now a whole new problematic, arising from post-Thomist thinking, one he sets forth under four headings: “the problem of patterns of human experience, of the *Denkformen*”; “the problem of the relations between speculative and positive theology”; “the problem of the relations between speculative theology and the empirical human sciences”; and a fourth area, not given a specific name, that raises questions ranging from epistemology to dialectic and foundations — we might, I think, call it the area of methodology.¹²

2. *The Middle Years*

The second period of Lonergan’s career, as I divide it, coincides approximately with his professorship at the Gregorian University, 1953-1965. It was then that he worked on his solutions to the new problems listed in the 1954 article. His reading too was extended now and his horizons broadened through contact with his huge multicultural audience. His *cursus speciales* in the university’s doctoral programs, along with the summer institutes and lectures he gave during these years, especially in the universities of Canada and the United States, provided a new stimulus for his thinking. It was very much, then, a time of experimenting with new ideas, though we should not forget that the arena, as it were, for testing the new ideas was still the familiar scene of traditional theological treatises.¹³

This period is fairly well documented through notes issued for his students, *reportationes* or tape-recordings of his lectures, and so

¹² GREGORIANUM, pp. 642-648; *Collection*, pp. 135-141.

¹³ This is another persistent misunderstanding, to think of Lonergan elaborating his method in isolation from theology and the life of the church. In fact, his method was worked out in continual reference to the traditional theology he taught for twenty-five years, especially the theology of divine grace, of the incarnate Word, and of the Holy Trinity.

on, but there do remain important gaps that need to be filled for a thorough study.¹⁴ In the present simplified study of the development relevant to Lonergan's pastoral theology, I would say that, though he was marshaling forces for a turn to the pastoral, the war was still being fought on another front over a prior question, that of transposition of the message from the sources of Christian theology to systematics.

Two quite distinct developments were involved here, and I would say that only one of them had been completed. Thus, Lonergan was vividly aware of the difference in thought-patterns between Palestinian and Scholastic manners of thinking and acting, and fully conscious of the problem of transposing from one to the other. But I do not think that he had yet taken the measure of what he would later call the classicist view of culture, or fully realized the importance for the pastoral side of the empirical notion of culture. In any case a central issue during all this period was how to effect a valid transition from Palestinian to Hellenic and then to Scholastic categories. Thus, in a course called *De intellectu et methodo*, given in the academic year, 1958-1959, he spoke of three aspects of the single problem of method: foundations, or transition from one ordering of doctrines to another; historicity, or continuity throughout the series of orderings; and estrangement or alienation, the distance intervening as systematics takes us farther and farther from our origins.¹⁵ How he would invoke and apply the notion of transposition to the solution of these problems is too long a story to tell here. It is indeed extremely important for understanding Lonergan's thinking, not only in this middle period but throughout his career, but I can only illustrate it by an example (enlarging somewhat one of his): thus, the Matthean image of the Son of Man coming in the clouds to the Ancient of days is transposed to the Pauline formulation of the Lord seated at the right hand of the

¹⁴ For example, there was a course at the Gregorian University, 1959-1960, called *De systemate et historia*; the title is revealing — the dialectic of system and history was a preoccupation of Lonergan at this time — but documentation on the course is inadequate. Again, there was an institute at Gonzaga University, Spokane, in 1963, and one at Georgetown University, Washington, 1964, just when Lonergan's thought was poised for an immense leap forward; but both of them, and especially the second, need further documentation.

¹⁵ On this work see my contribution, "Lonergan's Search for Foundations: The Early Years, 1940-1959," to PHILIP MCSHANE (ed.), *Searching for Cultural Foundations*, Lanham, Md.: University Press of America, 1984, pp. 113-139 and (notes) 187-197, especially pp. 130-134.

Father, which in turn is transposed to the Nicene doctrine of the Son who is consubstantial with the Father, and this again is transposed in Lonergan's use of the Athanasian doctrine that the same things are said of the Son as are said of the Father.¹⁶

We must remind ourselves that the three divisions in Lonergan's life are not sealed compartments. During these middle years there were breakthroughs, to use one of his favorite metaphors, all along the line, but not the encirclement and confinement that would clinch the matter. More properly put: Lonergan had not yet conceived the integral heuristic structure that would unify what he had to say on the method of theology, and provide a basis for correlating research and magisterium, system and preaching, tradition and innovation, receiving the deposit of faith and appropriating it personally. This would be achieved, in relatively stable if not completely elaborated fashion, in the third stage of his career.

3. *The Period of Integration*

To study pastoral aspects in the interwoven nest of ideas that constitute Lonergan's view on theological method, is to be led continually to and fro between single threads and the complex whole. For economy I will concentrate on one single thread and, without justifying my choice, separate out a new notion of culture as most directly relevant to the pastoral orientation of theology.

Here we are once again involved in the complex question of Lonergan's development, so I offer the following markers to the relevant history. Early in his career Lonergan came under the strong influence of Christopher Dawson's views on culture, and this influence was widely operative and long enduring, though it has never, so far as I know, been made the focus of special study. Anyway we have the remark made years later testifying to and dating this influence: "In the summer of 1930... Christopher Dawson's *The Age of the Gods* introduced me to the anthropological notion of culture and so began the correction of my hitherto normative or classicist notion."¹⁷ To begin the correction of an old

¹⁶ BERNARD LONERGAN, *The Way to Nicea: The Dialectical Development of Trinitarian Theology*, A translation by Conn O'Donovan, London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1976, pp. 88-104; there is discussion of this point passim in Lonergan's works.

¹⁷ *A Second Collection: Papers by Bernard J.F. Lonergan, S.J.*, London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1974, p. 264.

idea is by no means to see at once all the implications of the new, and I am inclined to think that the seed planted by his reading of Dawson lay dormant in Lonergan's mind for several years. *Insight* does not seem to have been greatly concerned with correcting the old view. The trinitarian theology of 1961 recognizes that the true reality of culture ("cultura veri nominis") is to be found in primitive tribes as well as in the great civilizations,¹⁸ but I interpret this as a rather abstract recognition, akin to Newman's notional apprehension of a truth, for application to the practical scene is still lacking. The following year there is clear advertence to the shift from classical culture to historical consciousness, which "effects the transition from an ideal order — what the family, the state, the law, education, the economy should be — to what *de facto* is," but even now there is a certain nostalgia for the old: "classical culture is not something to be sniffed at: it ran the world from the fifth century B. C. to the French Revolution."¹⁹ The next two years, however, saw a full acceptance of the new. In a 1964 lecture Lonergan remarks that the word, *aggiornamento*, "has electrified the world... because it seems to imply a rejection of classicism, a rejection of the view that human nature is always the same."²⁰ This is fully spelled out one year later:

by and large, classical culture has passed away. By and large, its canons of art, its literary forms, its rules of correct speech, its norms of interpretation, its ways of thought, its manner in philosophy, its notion of science, its concept of law, its moral standards, its methods of education, are no longer accepted... Classical culture has given way to a modern culture, and, I would submit, the crisis of our age is in no small measure the fact that modern culture has not yet reached its maturity.²¹

From this time on the contrast between the classicist and the empirical notions of culture is a recurring theme; it is domiciled in Lonergan's thought.²²

¹⁸ *De Deo Trino: Pars analytica*, Rome: Gregorian University Press, 1961, p. 84.

¹⁹ Institute on the Method of Theology, Regis College, Toronto, 1962. The lectures were tape-recorded by a person or persons unknown; the tapes were transcribed by John Brezovec; and the latter's handwritten text was the basis for a typescript by Nicholas Graham (see this, pp. 112-113, for the quoted lines).

²⁰ *Collection*, p. 248, in the chapter, "Existenz and Aggiornamento."

²¹ *Ibid.*, pp. 258-259, in the chapter, "Dimensions of Meaning."

²² See the indices to *A Second Collection* (lectures between 1966 and 1973), and *Method in Theology*.

This does not mean there will be at once that application to the pastoral work of the church which we will presently find in Chapter 14 of *Method*. There is a time lag to be explained here, but I would attribute it less to lack of development in the notion of culture itself, and much more to lack of a structure into which the new notion of culture could fit and find its proper application; once the structure was in place, as it was by 1965, the full riches of the new notion of culture could pour into the idea of communications. At any rate it is this notion that in my view is the key to this crowning specialty, and thus to a full and integral idea of theology. Certainly it is of major importance for Lonergan's position on inculturation, which is so closely linked with the specialty of communications. Not that Lonergan adopts the word, inculturation, so far as I remember, but that is the right name for the process he describes in communications, and the underlying supposition is always his empirical notion of culture. Consider the following passage:

The Christian message is to be communicated to all nations. Such communication presupposes that preachers and teachers enlarge their horizons to include an accurate and intimate understanding of the culture and the language of the people they address. They must grasp the virtual resources of that culture and that language, and they must use those virtual resources creatively so that the Christian message becomes, not disruptive of the culture, not an alien patch superimposed upon it, but a line of development within the culture.²³

The classicist would preach not only the gospel but also the classicist culture and thus "confer the double benefit of both the true religion and the true culture. In contrast, the pluralist acknowledges a multiplicity of cultural traditions."²⁴

This then is the main development in Lonergan's thought that forms the relevant background to his views on the pastoral task. But what that task is in itself and in relation to the original Christian message, what the roles respectively of theologians and church authorities in regard to it, how it relates to the various specialties of research, interpretation, history and dialectic, and how one effects the transition from a critical assimilation of the past to a personal challenging of oneself and one's time, all these are further questions.

²³ *Method in Theology*, p. 362.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 363.

Some of them find answers in Lonergan's *Method*, many of them are left to be worked out by those who would implement the method. I will conclude my article with some remarks on such problems.

III. *Lonergan's Method and the Pastoral Task*

Lonergan worked actively for nearly eleven years after the publication of *Method*. It was a period in which his powers were still creative, one in which, had he known that time would be granted him, he might have effected a massive return to theology after his long withdrawal. But he did not know that eleven years remained, had reason in fact to expect a shorter period; in any case, he felt that others could take over the unfinished theological task, while he probably felt his work in economics needed his own input still. Thus it is that, though he has given, through the lectures of this period, scattered hints on a return to theology, the work of implementing his method was left to be undertaken by his theological heirs. It is with a sense of the responsibility that such a legacy imposes on us that I propose the reflections of this concluding section.

To be constantly remembered: religion and theology are here conceived as distinct areas involving distinct activities. Religion precedes theology and would remain even if theology disappeared. Theology is a reflection on religion, a reflection that might, in Newman's theory of knowledge, be considered an end in itself, but in the total context has the practical function of mediating between religion and culture. Theology is not, however, any and every reflection on religion: the mother of Jesus and Thomas Aquinas both pondered the word of God, but Thomas did so with the aid of a highly specialized method and expressed his reflections in a highly specialized language that Mary would have found incomprehensible. Now, as religion receives a tradition to hand it on, so also does theology; but in the latter's specialized methods both the receiving and the handing on divide into four functions, distinguished, related and integrated as the four levels of human consciousness are distinguished, related and integrated. That structure will provide the context for my remarks.

The first phase of theology, the reception of the Christian heritage, divides into the specialties of research, interpretation, history, and dialectic. Of these the first three are more familiar as the work of "scholarship" — in Lonergan's sense of that word, in which

it refers to particular knowledge of another culture and, even more specifically, of the common sense of that other culture, though it may be combined with science or knowledge of universal laws. There are probably very few pure examples of these specialties, but Merk's *Novum Testamentum Graece et Latine*, Dodd's *The Interpretation of the Fourth Gospel*, and Grillmeier's *Christ in Christian Tradition from the Apostolic Age to Chalcedon*, three works well known to Lonergan, would exemplify quite well the relevant areas of scholarship. These areas are not, however, directly related to pastoral work: pastors do not often need to study the variants in New Testament manuscripts, or patristic subtleties on the God-Man and *Logos-Sarx* patterns of thinking; if the need arises for this kind of erudition, the pastor will have recourse to the experts: the researchers, the exegetes, the historians. Conversely, the scholar-theologian will not ordinarily need to introduce his learning directly into his preaching.

The directly pastoral function comes to light and is exercised in the second phase, in which theologians have to provide a creative restatement of their faith. But the utterly essential prerequisite to that restatement is a dialectical critique of the past, or the fourth specialty of the first phase. Lonergan's own work on patristic trinitarian theology illustrates very well, if only partially, such a critique, and happily we have, in *The Way to Nicea*,²⁵ an English version of the most relevant part of that work. While some historians, then, see pre-Nicene theology as strewn with the corpses of subordinationist doctrine on the Son, Lonergan finds it quite misleading to speak of subordinationism in this period. What was occurring was a dialectical self-correcting process as the community of theologians strove to bring their imperfect conception and often faulty expression into conformity with their own and the church's underlying faith. It was work of an ongoing community, as it must be, for the individual theologian cannot, in the nature of the case, be aware of a correction that lies in the future and will often be achieved only in reference to, and through the enlarging of, the narrow horizon that was the source of the mistake. Study of horizons is the key task in this specialty, and Lonergan therefore

²⁵ See note 16 supra; the translation covers pp. 17-112 in a book of 308 pages. The work illustrates only *partially* the specialty of dialectic because it deals almost exclusively with the cognitive aspect, and because it is a study of an ancient dialectic: we ourselves are not very directly involved.

investigates the horizons operative in Tertullian, Origen, and Athanasius, in order to account for their several theologies, and to discern, through what he calls an X-ray of history, the fundamental structure of the development taking place in them.²⁶

Theology, then, even in phase one, is a learning process long before it becomes a doctrine to be taught and, insofar as the trinitarian case is an instance of a basic human process, it becomes a paradigm for all theology. That is, if what happened on the way to Nicea happened as it did, not because of the obduracy of subordinationist heretics but because of the nature of human pondering on mystery, then it will happen that way over and over again. Two questions leap at once to mind. Where is it happening today, in regard to what questions of theology? And, what can the theologian do to expedite a happy outcome of the learning process? An answer to the first is difficult without the hindsight of next century, and an answer to the second is rendered difficult by our own involvement in the process: we are no longer spectators coolly observing the antics of a Tertullian or an Origen. Still, the effort should be made, and the strategy imposes itself: to study the horizons, including our own, of those engaged in the process, while remaining open to the broadened horizons and the conversions the times, and the Spirit, may require of us.

Besides dialectical critique there is creative reformulation. Those whom we are pleased to call "simple believers" may hand on to their children the faith they received, and do so without sensing the need of reformulation; so may fundamentalists, at home or on the missions. But once we recognize the diversity of cultures in the peoples of the world, and indeed the changing face of culture within our own borders and within our own generation, that procedure is seen to be inadequate. It was awareness of this inadequacy that lay behind the urgent appeal of Pope John XXIII at the time of the Second Vatican Council, when he stated that the church did not need a reiteration of ancient doctrine, but must take a leap forward and give new expression to her teaching.²⁷ Here too then, and even more

²⁶ *The Way to Nicea*, Lonergan's new "Foreword," p. viii.

²⁷ Two speeches of Pope John are relevant, one at the opening of the Second Vatican Council, another a few weeks after the end of the first session (it is in the latter that the expression, a leap forward — *un balzo innanzi* — occurs); see *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 54 (1962) 791-792, and 55 (1963) 43-45. I owe the references to LONERGAN's paper, "Pope John's Intention"; see *A Third Collection: Papers by*

than in phase one, theology is primarily a learning process. Lonergan's effort to transpose old dogmas into new and meaningful doctrines is, in other words, a struggle to learn.

Doctrines, however, become meaningful through personal appropriation, so the foundations for the required transposition are placed in interiority. Not that interiority grounds for us the ancient dogma — we must be clear on that; it grounds only the transposition of the ancient dogma into new expression,²⁸ so that the total foundation for Pope John's new expression will be a resultant, as it were, of two vector forces; one deriving from the past where we find formulations, within a certain horizon, of the church's faith, and the other deriving from our own creativity as we express the same faith within our different horizon. To be noted again: it is not interiority as a purely private possession that is our guide, but interiority expressed in community and tested by community dialogue.

There follows on doctrines, as has been the case from time immemorial, the need for systematic understanding, the old *fides quaerens intellectum*, once thought to constitute theology *tout court*, but now reduced to but one function out of eight. So we come, finally, to the immediate pastoral task of communications, but communications carried out on the basis of our new understanding of the diversity of cultures, and of our new realization of the need, as was said, so to preach the Christian message that it becomes, "not disruptive of the culture, not an alien patch superimposed upon it, but a line of development within the culture."²⁹

The assimilative power of the structure I have outlined needs testing, and a locus for the test might well be found in the questions that surfaced at the recent extraordinary synod of bishops. Let me illustrate that through two examples. The first is the proposal of the Most Reverend Bernard Hubert, Bishop of Saint-Jean-Longueuil

that we identify the problems that the Synod wishes to deal with and bring ourselves up-to-date next year or even later. This would allow the Synod Fathers to go back and discuss the themes considered with the members of their episcopal conferences and with all the members of the people of God responsible for the mission of the church.³⁰

Bernard J.F. Lonergan, S.J., New York: Paulist Press, and London: Chapman, 1985, pp. 224-238.

²⁸ *Method in Theology*, p. 267.

²⁹ *Ibid.*, p. 362.

³⁰ *L'Osservatore Romano*, Weekly Edition (English), Dec. 16, 1985, p. 12.

Now this proposal is exactly in line with Lonergan's theological method and would really test his second phase. What Bishop Hubert implies in his "two-stage synodal process" is that the church, the whole church, is a learning church, and that what we need to learn is not the ancient formulas, which we can find in a good catechism, or even the erudite nuances of the ancient formulas, which we can find by consulting the scholars, but the new expression, Pope John's "leap forward," that the times and the Spirit require, or, in Lonergan's preferred terms, learn how to transpose the old dogmas into newly formulated doctrines.

The whole effort should be seen as the intention to save what is valid and reject what is harmful in each of two extreme positions. For the reactionary is quite right in trying to save an ancient faith, but quite wrong in thinking to save it by merely repeating the formulas of Nicea, Chalcedon, and Vatican I. Equally the radical is quite right in critiquing the dogmatic formulations of the past in terms of the horizon in which they were uttered, but quite wrong in a declaration of independence from those formulations. The transpositions proposed by Lonergan would save what is valid and reject what is harmful in both positions, but would require, almost by definition, that return to God's people urged by Bishop Hubert, or what Lonergan and others would call "feedback."³¹ This clarifies the role of the local bishop in what must be the primary task for the whole church: learning before we undertake to teach; in the present case learning through research and interpretation what the manifestations of the Spirit are in the local church. When Catholics try to persuade their governments to establish an embassy at the Vatican, they often make much of the latter as a "listening post." The religious and theological needs of our time suggest a parallel role for the local bishop, and much more for national conferences of

³¹ The concept of feedback, though the word may occur only occasionally, is extremely important in Lonergan; it is almost identical with the Canon of Operations of *Insight* — see the Index under "Canon," also pp. xiv (xv in 4th ed.), 35, 100, 104, 166, 174, 223, 226, 228-229, 303, 688, etc. In *Method*, see pp. 88 (n. 34), 293, 361, 366, etc.; in *A Second Collection*, pp. 191, 216; and in *A Third Collection*, pp. 29-30, 105-106. So far as I know this concept and its role in Lonergan's thought have not been the focus of any study, though they are touched on here and there in the literature; see, for example, JOHN A. RAYMAKER, "The Theory-Praxis of Social Ethics: The Complementarity Between Hermeneutical and Dialectical Foundations," in MATTHEW L. LAMB (ed.), *Creativity and Method: Essays in Honor of Bernard Lonergan, S.J.*, Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 1981, pp. 339-352 (especially pp. 349-352).

bishops: that of a listening post for the voice of the Holy Spirit. Of course, what local bishops or national conferences “hear” is to be tested in dialogue with other bishops in world assembly with the Holy Father, just as individual interiority is to be tested in dialogue with the wider community.

A second example, taken from the same synod, reveals the relevance of Lonergan’s structure to the teaching, as well as to the learning, church: it is the question of a universal teaching vis-à-vis the particular cultural needs of the local church. The two need not be seen in opposition. For, if the church must learn before it can teach, and if it is the universal church that learns securely, then the very expression by the bishops, uttered in world assembly, of what they have learned, automatically becomes the teaching of the universal church.³² But that brings us to a second major function of the local bishops or national conferences: their teaching role. For a document produced by a world assembly, and so generalized that it can be a basis for Catholic teaching anywhere, is not likely to be a thrill to read or a joy to teach, nor can it in the very nature of the case provide an adequate doctrinal content for the local church. This must involve the local bishop and national conference, for the same bishops who brought their reports to the world assembly and made their contribution to the sixth functional specialty of doctrines are the very ones who will return to the local church and, aware of local culture in a way the world assembly could not possibly be, so preach the universal Christian message that it becomes, “not disruptive of the culture, not an alien patch superimposed upon it, but a line of development within the culture.”

What will the role of theologians be in this ongoing, never-ending work of learning and teaching? It will be as diversified as the eight functions of theology. As scholars they will provide the research, interpretation and history the church requires to make her return to the sources academically sound. As horizon-analysts (we have no word yet for those who will exercise the fourth function),³³

³² Readers of *Method in Theology* will ask me whether I have not oversimplified the question of doctrines; in that book LONERGAN distinguishes primary sources, church doctrines, theological doctrines, methodological doctrine, and the doctrines of the sixth functional specialty (p. 295). Yes, I have, but in the direction, I think, of reuniting some of what has been distinguished; that is, Lonergan surely hoped that the doctrines of his sixth specialty would contribute to church doctrines for our times, and I would see Bishop Hubert’s proposal as heading along the same route to the same unity.

³³ I derive the term from the cognate, horizon analysis, which I first noticed in

they will encounter the past with a sense of the different horizons operative in different times, with the task of critiquing the horizons of antiquity but equally with the task of broadening their own horizons in encounter with both antiquity and the present. As category-creators (again we have no word for those who work in the fifth function of foundations, though we might agree on “foundational theologians”), they will attempt to bring to suitable expression the present religious experience of the people of God, and thus provide the bishops with categories for the doctrines to be formulated in their assemblies. Then there is systematic theology, once the reigning but now the dethroned sovereign of the realm. Earlier we moved in a rather facile way from the sixth function of doctrines (bishops in world assembly) to the eighth function of communications (bishops on the local scene). But what is facile in the abstract can hardly be achieved in the concrete without the wide perspective and integral view deriving from a grasp of all eight specialties in their distinction, relation and unity, and this is the task of systematics. It is illuminating to note that it is a new task: not only must systematics unify the objective content of theology (God and all things in relation to God, as Aquinas put it), but it must unify as well the functions and operations of the theologians, from positive scholars working on the past to pastors bringing the message to the present people of God.

If my reading of Lonergan is correct, he regarded the whole church as involved in the double process of learning and teaching; in the perspective of that position it is, of course, legitimate and necessary to divide the people of God according to their roles in the teaching function. But it is also secondary, and the whole question becomes distorted if the prior learning function is not brought into the perspective. When a university excludes a branch of science, Newman held, not only is there a gap in its program but the sciences that remain are distorted. Something parallel, I would say, has happened in regard to the learning and teaching functions of the church: we have so neglected the one and so stressed the other that we have become like a bird with one wing overdeveloped and the other atrophied. And this can happen without positive exclusion of the learning function: from the Boy and then the Man Jesus to the

DAVID W. TRACY, “Horizon Analysis and Eschatology,” *Continuum*, Vol. 6, No. 2 (Summer 1968), pp. 166-179, and subsequently in various studies of Lonergan.

Second Vatican Council the learning function is acknowledged. What is lacking is attention to learning as a problem, study of its implications, development of its criteria, responsible assumption of the tasks involved. If Lonergan has anything to say to pastors it regards their teaching, and if he has anything to say on teaching it is that if we would teach we must first be willing to learn. What, after all, was his long withdrawal but a massive effort to learn, first from Thomas Aquinas and then from the seven centuries that followed Thomas?³⁴ Can we, his heirs, take up the teaching task without following the same route?

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RÉSUMÉ

L'oeuvre de Lonergan a été considérée comme excessivement intellectuelle. L'article veut corriger cette impression en montrant le souci pastoral qui guida Lonergan à travers toute sa carrière. Cette préoccupation se révèle dans l'effort qu'il déploie pour chercher une solution aux problèmes sous-jacents aux misères économiques de notre siècle; et davantage encore dans l'intention profonde de sa théologie, à savoir une recherche persévérante de la communication en vue de prêcher la parole aux hommes là où ils se trouvent.

La stratégie de son approche théologique fait cependant problème. En termes génériques on peut la décrire comme un mouvement de repli et de retour: il s'agit d'aller aux racines mêmes d'un problème en vue de retourner ensuite au concret, armé d'une puissante analyse de la solution. La partie principale de l'article étudie cette stratégie telle qu'elle se développe en trois étapes au cours de l'affrontement de toute une carrière aux problèmes de la théologie.

Lonergan lui-même n'a jamais réalisé pleinement le retour au concret vers lequel tendait sa théologie. Il a plutôt bâti des routes que tracé des plans. En conclusion l'article suggère comment sa pensée créatrice pourrait être mise à profit en vue de l'inculturation de la foi en notre temps.

³⁴ Readers of *Insight* will remember the much-quoted line in which he speaks of "spending years reaching up to the mind of Aquinas" (p. 748); years later he remarked to me (in a letter dated March 3, 1980): "I fear that my book did not emphasize enough the importance of research: my own work in that specialty was *Gratia operans* and *Verbum*, about eleven years of my life."

As for his effort to learn from the seven centuries that followed Aquinas, one can hardly do better than read the original (discarded) Preface to *Insight*, now printed in *METHOD: Journal of Lonergan Studies*, Vol. 3, No. 1 (March, 1985), pp. 3-7. Note especially the remark (p. 4), "But if I may borrow a phrase from Ortega y Gasset, one has to strive to mount to the level of one's time."